

Elevance Payer Policy: Lumbar Spine MRI

CPT/HCPCS Code: 72148 | Version: 2026-Q3 | Effective Date: 2026-07-01

Specialty Requirement

This service requires a referral from: Orthopedic Surgery, Neurosurgery, or Neurology referral.

Required Supporting Documentation

1. Primary Care Clinical Assessment Notes
2. Conservative Physical Therapy Logs

Clinical Prerequisites

1. Lower back pain radiating down the leg or signs of radiculopathy
2. Trial of conservative physical therapy for at least 6 weeks
3. Trial of conservative drug therapy (NSAIDs or analgesics) for at least 4 weeks

Notes

Requests lacking any of the required supporting documentation above will be returned to the provider for additional evidence unless the case includes clearly documented exigent circumstances warranting expedited review.